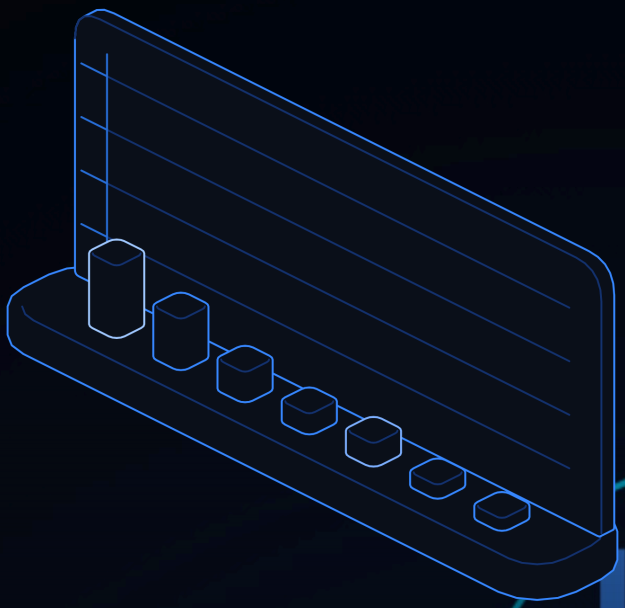
TRANSPUTEC

HOT TOPICS · PLAYBOOK
NO. 04 · NOVEMBER 2026



HOT TOPICS · THE AI VALUE RECKONING

Make AI pay.

Spending on AI keeps climbing while proof of return lags. How to pick use cases that pay, prove them, keep agents in check and know when to stop.

INSIDE

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A practical guide to the 2026 AI value reckoning: choosing use cases that pay, proving them, keeping agents under control and reporting value the board can trust. Numbered citations refer to the sources list in the companion report, The AI Reckoning.

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FOREWORD

The question has changed from what AI can do to what it has done for us.

Through 2026 the numbers have told two stories. Gartner expects worldwide AI spending of about $2.67 trillion this year, up by roughly half.[2] Yet McKinsey's annual survey found the share of organisations reporting any profit impact from AI unchanged at 37%.[3]

Boards have noticed. So have finance teams, who are being asked to approve renewals, usage bills and agent projects with very little evidence to go on. At the same time, AI agents that act on their own have arrived in production, and with them a new kind of incident: the action that has to be reversed.

This playbook is about the practical response. It does not argue for less AI or more. It shows how to put AI investment on the same footing as any other: a measured starting point, a clear target, controls proportionate to the risk, honest reporting and the discipline to stop what does not pay.



The Transputec team
Transputec

INTRODUCTION

Value is made in the workflow, not the licence.

The organisations reporting real returns from AI are not using secret models. They choose carefully, measure from day one and run AI like any other part of the business.

Choose for measurable value

Start where the outcome is already counted: cost per case, cycle time, error rates or revenue.

Control agents before they act

Approval points, full logging, a kill switch and a tested way to undo. Build them in, not on.

Report it like an investment

A baseline, a target, a running cost and a date to decide whether to scale or stop.

If you cannot measure it before, you cannot claim it after.

Every AI initiative in this playbook starts with a baseline and ends with a decision.

01

PART 01

Find the value.

Pick the few use cases that can pay, and measure where you start.

01 Why returns lag

02 Choosing use cases

03 Baselining

FIND THE VALUE

Why so much AI spend has not paid back yet

> **Lots of small experiments feel like progress. A few measured use cases usually make the money.**

Most organisations did not set out to waste money on AI. They bought licences because colleagues asked for them, ran pilots because vendors offered them and added AI features because their existing software included them. Each decision was reasonable. Together they rarely add up to a measurable result.

The evidence for that pattern is consistent. In McKinsey's 2026 survey, 80% of respondents said AI had improved their own productivity, but only 37% reported any effect on EBIT.[3] Personal time saved does not become money unless the work around it changes.

Three habits cause most of the gap. The first is choosing use cases by enthusiasm rather than value, so effort spreads thinly across dozens of experiments. The second is skipping the baseline, so nobody can show what changed. The third is treating AI as a tool to roll out rather than a change to how a process runs.

Costs make it worse. Usage-based pricing means a pilot that is cheap at ten users can be expensive at a thousand. One in five McKinsey respondents already say running costs limit their use of AI.[4]

Agents add a further twist. An agent that books, refunds, updates or sends on its own can save far more effort than an assistant, but each wrong action has a cost, and that cost is often missing from the business case.

The fix is not a new strategy document. It is a short list of use cases, a measured starting point, a cost envelope and an agreed date to decide.

CHOOSING USE CASES

Where AI is most likely to pay

Score each candidate on how measurable its value is and how ready the process and data are. Fund the top right first.

↑ MEASURABLE VALUE

FIX FIRST

Valuable, not ready

Clean the data or simplify the process before adding AI. Otherwise you automate the mess.

FUND NOW

Valuable and ready

High-volume, rules-heavy work with counted outcomes: service tickets, invoice queries, document intake, code review.

DROP

Unclear value, not ready

Interesting ideas with no owner, no data and no measure. Park them.

ALLOW, DO NOT FUND

Ready, value unclear

Personal productivity use within policy. Useful, but do not build a business case on it.

READINESS OF PROCESS AND DATA →

BASELINING

Baseline before you build

Two to four weeks of measurement before a pilot saves months of argument afterwards.

01 Name the outcome in money or time

Cost per case, hours per report, days to close, error rate or conversion. One primary measure per use case.

02 Measure the current process

Take at least four weeks of real data from your systems, not estimates from a workshop.

03 Record the full cost today

Staff time, outsourcing, rework and software, so the AI case has a fair comparison.

04 Agree the target and the threshold

What improvement justifies scaling, and what result means stop. Write both down before the pilot starts.

05 Pick a control group

Where possible, keep one team or region on the old process so you can separate AI effects from other changes.

REMEMBER

A baseline is the cheapest insurance you will buy in an AI programme.

MEASURES THAT MATTER

What to measure for each kind of use case

Match the measure to the job. Activity counts such as logins or prompts are not value.

USE CASE TYPE	PRIMARY MEASURE	WATCH ALONGSIDE
Service and support	Cost per resolved case; first contact resolution.	Customer satisfaction, escalations, reopened cases.
Document processing	Cases handled per person per day.	Error and exception rate, rework.
Software engineering	Lead time from change to production.	Defects found later, review load, security findings.
Sales and marketing	Conversion and revenue per rep or campaign.	Lead quality, brand and compliance issues.
Finance and back office	Days to close; cost per transaction.	Audit adjustments, control exceptions.
Agents acting on systems	Tasks completed without human rework.	Reversals, incidents, time to detect and undo.

02

PART 02

Prove it safely.

Pilots that answer a question, and agents that can be seen, stopped and undone.

01 Pilot design

02 Agent reliability controls

03 Three worked examples

PILOT DESIGN

A pilot that ends in a decision

Most pilots fail by never finishing. Design each one to answer a single question in a fixed time.

Frame

One use case, one primary measure, one accountable owner and a written stop or scale threshold.

Scope

Limit users, data and systems. For agents, start read-only or draft-only before allowing actions.

Run

Eight to twelve weeks on real work, with the baseline and control group running in parallel.

Judge

Compare against the baseline, include full running costs and every incident or reversal.

Decide

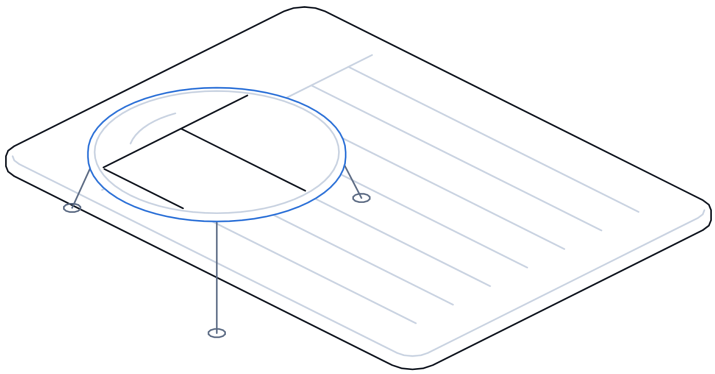
Scale, fix and retest once, or stop. Record the decision and the reason.

> A pilot without a stop threshold is not a pilot. It is an open-ended commitment.

AGENT RELIABILITY

Four controls every agent needs

Vendor surveys report many firms have reversed agent actions, and few can trace or stop agents automatically.[6,10]



01 **Least privilege**

Each agent runs under its own identity, with only the access its task needs.

02 **Approval points**

A person approves high-impact actions: payments, refunds, deletions and external messages.

03 **Observability**

Log every prompt, tool call and output against a case ID, so any action can be reconstructed.

04 **Stop and rollback**

A tested kill switch, reversible actions and backups for any data an agent can change.

01



Agent controls in practice

What to put in place before an agent moves from drafting to doing.

THIS WEEK

List every agent or automation that can act on a system. Record its identity, permissions and owner.

THIS MONTH

Add approval points for high-impact actions and switch on full logging. Test the kill switch.

THIS QUARTER

Run a rollback drill: reverse a batch of agent actions and restore data within an agreed time.

CHECK

Can you answer, for any agent action, who or what did it, why, and how to undo it?



OWNER

Head of IT, with each process owner

Bring this to the monthly review, with a date for each action.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Three use cases, run properly



CUSTOMER SERVICE

Agent-drafted replies to billing queries

BASELINE

Cost per resolved query and first contact resolution over six weeks.

CONTROL

Agent drafts; staff approve every reply that issues refunds or credits.

PAY TEST

Scale if cost per query falls 20% with no drop in satisfaction.

STOP RULE

Stop if escalations or reopened cases rise for two consecutive weeks.



FINANCE

Invoice intake and matching

BASELINE

Invoices processed per person per day and exception rate.

CONTROL

Agent matches and flags; humans approve payments. All actions logged.

PAY TEST

Scale if throughput rises and audit adjustments do not.

STOP RULE

Stop if exceptions rise or running costs exceed the saving.



IT

Agent-assisted ticket triage and fixes

BASELINE

Time to resolve and reopened tickets for common incidents.

CONTROL

Read-only first; scripted fixes need approval and have a rollback.

PAY TEST

Scale if resolution time falls with no rise in change failures.

STOP RULE

Stop if any untraceable change reaches production.

03

PART 03

Run it, report it.

Keep running costs in check, show the board what changed, and stop what does not pay.

01 Cost control

02 Reporting value

03 When to stop

COST CONTROL

Four ways to stop AI bills running away

Usage-based pricing rewards discipline. Set these up before you scale, not after the first invoice.

Budget per use case

Give each use case its own cost centre and monthly cap, so spend can be tied to outcomes.

Alerts and hard limits

Set usage alerts at 50%, 80% and 100% of budget, and hard limits on non-critical workloads.

Right-size the model

Use smaller, cheaper models for routine steps and reserve the largest for tasks that need them.

Review licences quarterly

Remove unused seats and overlapping tools. Bundled AI features are not free if nobody uses them.

> KPMG found 61% of organisations review AI costs at approval but only 12% consistently assess value against cost.[7] Do both.

REPORTING VALUE

A one-page AI report for the board

Quarterly, one page, the same structure every time. Boards trust what they can compare.

LINE	WHAT TO SHOW	OWNER
Spend	Total AI spend by use case: licences, usage, people and partners.	Finance lead
Outcomes	Primary measure against baseline and target for each use case.	Process owners
Cost per outcome	Running cost divided by cases, hours or revenue affected. Trend over time.	Finance lead
Incidents	Agent reversals, errors that reached customers, data issues and near misses.	Head of IT
Decisions	What was scaled, fixed or stopped this quarter, and why.	Accountable executive

WHEN TO STOP

Five signs a use case should stop

Stopping is not failure. It is how budget moves to the things that work.

01 **It missed its threshold by the agreed date**

If the target was fair and the pilot ran properly, honour the rule you wrote at the start.

02 **Running costs outgrow the benefit**

Cost per outcome is flat or rising after the learning period.

03 **It needs more checking than it saves**

Staff spend as long reviewing outputs as they would doing the work.

04 **You cannot trace or undo what it does**

Any agent that cannot be observed, stopped and reversed stays out of production.

05 **Nobody owns it**

No named owner, no budget line, no measure. Close it and reassign the effort.

YOUR PLAN

This week, this month, this quarter

A realistic sequence for a mid-sized UK organisation.

WHEN	ACTION	OWNER
This week	List all AI spend, licences, pilots and agents. Name an owner for each.	Finance and IT
This week	Identify agents that can act on systems and check their permissions.	Head of IT
This month	Choose three use cases with measurable value and start baselining.	Executive sponsor
This month	Set cost caps and alerts on every usage-billed AI service.	Finance lead
This quarter	Run pilots to a stop or scale decision; stop at least one weak initiative.	Process owners
This quarter	Present the first one-page AI value report to the board.	Accountable executive

ASK YOUR SUPPLIERS

Questions for AI vendors and partners

Use these before you sign or renew.

VALUE AND COST

- ? What measurable outcome have comparable customers achieved, against what baseline?
- ? How is usage billed, and what controls cap our spend?
- ? What happens to price as our usage grows?

AGENTS AND CONTROL

- ? Can every agent action be logged, traced to a case and exported to our systems?
- ? How do we approve, pause and reverse agent actions?
- ? What access does the agent need, and can it be narrowed?

CHECKLIST

Is your AI investment set up to pay?

Tick what is true today. Anything blank is your next action.

- [ ] **Every AI initiative has a named owner**
  And a budget line.

- [ ] **Each funded use case has a baseline**
  Measured from real data.

- [ ] **Targets and stop rules are written down**
  Before the pilot starts.

- [ ] **Agents run with least privilege**
  Under their own identities.

- [ ] **High-impact agent actions need approval**
  Payments, deletions, external messages.

- [ ] **Agent activity is fully logged and traceable**
  And a kill switch has been tested.

- [ ] **Usage costs are capped and reviewed monthly**
  Per use case.

- [ ] **The board receives a quarterly value report**
  Including what was stopped.

GLOSSARY

Words worth knowing

Baseline

Performance measured before a change, used to judge its effect.

AI agent

An AI system that takes actions in other systems, not just answers.

Approval point

A step where a person must approve an agent's action before it happens.

Kill switch

A tested way to stop an agent immediately.

Rollback

Reversing an action or withdrawing an agent from service.

Observability

Logs and traces that show what a system did and why.

Least privilege

Giving each identity only the access its task requires.

Cost per outcome

Running cost divided by the cases, hours or revenue affected.

Control group

A team kept on the old process for comparison.

Stop rule

A pre-agreed result that ends an initiative.

TRANSPUTEC

Make your AI spend count.

Transputec helps UK organisations choose AI use cases that pay, put agents under proper control and report value the board can trust.

Book an AI value review

transputec.com

READ THE COMPANION REPORT

The AI Reckoning · Intelligence report No. 04

